

with Spaniards in control of most of it. If you've ever dreamed of living in old Los Angeles, Monterey, or San Francisco when those "pueblos" were part of Mexico and the Spanish empire, you'll fall in love with Guadalajara. The city center has five major plazas, each with an impressive church and spacious gardens. Colonial buildings grace the older streets, and bright cotton materials splash the stores and sidewalks with color.

*Choose Mexico* reports that Guadalajara is cheaper than almost any other part of Mexico. Because of the large number of retired Americans there, you can readily find a house to take care of while the owners are visiting the kids back "home" in New Jersey. You have to be willing to move every so often. But by house-sitting you can live rent-free in country villas, lakeside estates, or large city houses or apartments.

Guadalajara beats Rio or Madrid in its proximity to the United States. Visitors from Los Angeles or Houston can drive. Others can fly in a couple of hours, often on direct flights.

A city of 5 million people, Rio de Janeiro used to be Brazil's capital and most important city. That changed about twenty years ago, when the government moved the capital to Brasília. São Paulo has taken over as the country's manufacturing and business center. Rio has been relegated to a new status as Brazil's third city. But its residents seem to be making up for the change by having more fun than anybody else. In chapter 5 I talked about Brazil's fun-loving, sensuous people, and Rio is the center of the action.

What hits the first-time visitor to Rio is its breathtaking natural beauty. Stark mountains, sandy beaches, tropical islands, and the Atlantic Ocean combine in a spectacular setting. In my experience the three most beautiful cities in the world are San Francisco, Hong Kong, and Rio. But of the three, Rio is the only one with long, sunny beaches in the